

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

This month, we explore supercomputers in fiction in Geek Key, we learn more about the interesting ways in which steam-powered engines are used, and we converse with Ubisoft and DE-CIX in Backtalk. Then, take a look at some swanky gadgets, and we review some tech, a TV show, movie, and more in DGT.



A robot wrote this article

AI makes the case on why humans should trust it, because AI does not want to take over humanity, enslave them, or kill them. This robot makes a case for humans to trust machines. Will it manage to convince you?

<http://dgit.in/aitruce>

WHAT'S NEW

Painted wind turbines reduce bird deaths

A nine year long study conducted at the Smøla wind farm in Norway has shown that painting a single blade of a windmill black, can reduce deaths of birds by as much as seventy percent. In the US, about 300,000 birds die every year after encounters with wind turbines, but the number is still at least two orders of magnitude smaller than the number of birds killed after encounters with power lines. Even though the number is small, it is used by politicians, especially those with an axe to grind against environmentalists and eco friendly policies, to lobby for a greater reliance on traditional methods



of power generation, including coal, and to prevent wind farms from cropping up. US President Donald

Trump has pointed out

the problem with wind turbines and bird deaths in efforts to keep the coal industry alive. The Russian President Vladimir Putin has also pointed out the deaths caused by wind turbines, but advocated the development of alternative energy sources while keeping in mind the associated problems.

<http://dgit.in/paintedturbines>

Aerosols and the spread of the virus

The public interest messaging by the WHO and the national bodies for healthcare around the world are so far focused on two modes of transmission for the novel coronavirus, through fomites and droplets. These are the transmission modes that most of the preventive measures for the spread of the virus are focused around. A group of scientists are trying to raise the issue that a third mode of transmission, one through aero-



sols, is not being given enough attention. Aerosols are similar to droplets, but are much smaller. There is plenty of evidence to show that the novel coronavirus spreads through aerosols as well. This means that the virus spreads even when people talk,

without coughing. In fact since the 1900s, the ability of aerosols to spread diseases has been suppressed in science, because of the inertia of outdated scientific beliefs. Only a few diseases have been accepted by the scientific community as being able to spread through aerosols, including measles and chickenpox, and that was only after overwhelming evidence in support of the same was found.

<http://dgit.in/arsolcovid>



The rich have escaped to their bunkers

The wealthy have retreated to their cocoons, fortresses they had built in anticipation of the next big event, and the outbreak of the novel coronavirus may have just given them the excuse they needed to isolate themselves into private bubbles.

<http://dgit.in/richbubble>



Teach machines cause and effect

Judea Pearl, who pioneered artificial intelligence technologies as we know it today in the 1980s, says that on a fundamental level AI is still where it was three decades ago, and machines need to understand cause and effect more deeply instead of just making probabilistic predictions.

<http://dgit.in/ainext>



Auto WB ruining photos

Residents of San Francisco and Portland wanted to share apocalyptic photos of the skies and environments during the wildfires last months, but the thick orange haze was filtered out by the white balance settings in smartphones, which made the photos more normal looking.

<http://dgit.in/phonewb>